

Functional paranoia

IT'S ALWAYS A GOOD FEELING when you get more than what you've paid for. The gradual rise in oxytocin levels as you get a little something extra in your hands is a familiar sensation. Say you're at your local grocery store, and the grocer throws in an extra sachet of pickles, or when your sabjiwala remembers that you always ask for an extra bunch of curry leaves and hands you some without asking. With technology, we get to experience this happiness when incremental software patches resolve long-standing issues or when they introduce new features altogether. For example, Xiaomi just announced that they'll be pushing Widevine Level 1 DRM certification to the Poco F1 with the next OS update, thereby enabling HotStar and Amazon Prime Video to stream in Full HD as opposed to the 720p resolution that users get with Widevine L2. These little surprises help build the brand image and strengthen the consumers' faith in the brand as one that cares about consumer satisfaction. You know where this is going, don't you?

Once in a blue moon, things don't exactly work out in the same manner. Ask Google since they recently found out the hard way. Folks who'd bought the Nest home security system were surprised to know that an upcoming software update would add a new feature to their Nest devices – Google Assistant. Normally, you'd be happy to know that a voice assistant is being retroactively introduced, after all, it's the rage right now. Amazon Alexa and Google Assistant are currently engaged in an arms race to get as many devices as possible to integrate voice assistants. Alas, Nest consumers were enraged with the upcoming feature introduction. Why? Because, nobody told Nest owners that their devices had a microphone inbuilt. It was never mentioned in any of the advertisements or marketing material. In fact, even the data sheet (which nobody usually looks at) had no mention of the same. It's as if Google went skeet shooting with people's trust – trust being the skeets that rise high in the sky before being shot to smithereens with a 12-gauge shotgun!

I'll admit, even I was surprised by the whole incident. I don't own any of these smart devices. Not that I'm not excited about the prospect of what they're capable of doing, but I prefer to be in control of my privacy, as much as I possibly can. That's why the first thing I did when I

got my new Android phone was to delete every single unwanted package before I even logged in with my ID. Does the phone have a custom service to login? Yes, but I'll pass. It's also why I have a VPN activated at all times and have IP drop tables configured in my home routers. If there's a possibility for me to control my data, I will have a crack at it. I never use the fingerprint scanner and the same goes for the face unlock feature. The good old pattern lock works best even now. The list goes on and on. So you might wonder, why am I bothered with getting an Android phone to begin with? Doesn't that make me sort of a hypocrite?

To be honest, I prefer the term 'functional paranoid.' Yes, I do take extraordinary precautions with things that would be considered non-issues by the vast majority but I don't shy away from giving in if the pros outweigh the cons. For example, I have no qualms with having my GPS on all the time. This way, the security app installed on my phone can keep records of wherever my phone is at all times. Nor do I have any issues with using Google or Facebook to log into services. Why? Because I have *cough* alternate accounts that were made for that very purpose. So it doesn't bother me much when every other week we see a massive password dump of yet another online service appear on blackhat forums. Yeah, they most certainly have the account ID and password of my alt accounts but should my main account ever be compromised, a host of fallback accounts are ready to take their place. Think of it as a digital bug out bag. For the average guy, this is paranoia, for me, it's just the rational thing to do in this day and age. 



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